

Plan of Work: Scholarship Preparation

Year 7, Summer Holiday 2026, with Dr Sam

Overview:

These classes are designed to prepare students for scholarship exams at the major public schools. Their focus is on developing the skills that will be needed, when the time comes, to achieve high marks in the scholarship exam papers, in English and History.

Breakdown of skills:

These skills include but are not limited to:

Literary analysis. (Precise understanding of literary techniques: form, structure, figurative language etc.)

Historical analysis. (The ability to interpret historical sources accurately and intelligently: inference, context, reliability etc.)

Essay writing. (Knowing how to structure an argument in the appropriate shape and of appropriate length for an exam answer: forms of argument, basic dialectics, rhetorical presentation etc.)

Creative writing. (This one is a little different from the others: it is often said that creativity cannot be taught, which may or may not be true. What I can teach, however, is a set of tools and tricks which, when deployed in the exam, will tend to bring a student higher marks for their answer. These are technical things: a student doesn't need to be a 'natural writer' to do well in creative writing questions, they need only to know how to deploy the tools of creative writing effectively.)

My approach:

Each class has a focus: either a literary text or some historical subject. They are chosen carefully to facilitate the teaching of some or other aspect of the skills mentioned above. The classes will be split between analysis and writing; the precise division will depend on the subject or text we are addressing. Below is a breakdown of each class. I have listed the relevant text or subject and the particular skill(s) it will allow us to work on.

PLAN OF WORK:

1) English

Six Poems on Summer

Summer is one of the oldest subjects in English poetry, and one of the most elastic: the same season can be made to mean love, idleness, abundance, or loss. This class will read a selection of short poems on summer — including

work by Emily Dickinson, Edward Thomas, and John Clare — and ask how form, sound, and image carry meaning across very different moods.

2) General

What Makes You You? The Problem of Personal Identity

What makes you the same person you were ten years ago, when almost every cell in your body has been replaced? This class will work through a series of puzzles about personal identity — the Ship of Theseus, the teleporter, the gradual replacement of the brain — and ask whether the self is the body, the memory, or something else entirely.

3) History

The French Revolution

In 1789 the French monarchy collapsed under the weight of debt, hunger, and an idea. This class will read sources from across the Revolution — the Tennis Court Oath, the Rights of Man, Burke, Olympe de Gouges, and Robespierre — and ask whether the Revolution is best read as the birth of modern liberty or as a warning against it.

4) English

Four Openings

How a novel begins is often a more revealing test of its style than any single passage that follows. This class will read the opening pages of four novels — Charlotte Brontë's *Jane Eyre*, Stevenson's *Treasure Island*, Daphne du Maurier's *Rebecca*, and Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* — and consider how each writer establishes voice, atmosphere, and a relationship with the reader within the first hundred words.

5) General

What Is Justice? The Ring of Gyges

In Plato's *Republic*, Glaucon tells the story of a shepherd who finds a ring that makes him invisible, and asks whether anyone who could escape all consequences would still choose to be good. This class will use the story to open the question of what justice is, and whether we value it for its own sake or only for the rewards it brings.

6) History

The Children's Crusade

In 1212, thousands of young people across France and Germany reportedly set out to recapture the Holy Land by faith alone. The movement ended in disaster: many died, others were allegedly sold into slavery, and none reached Jerusalem.

But did it really happen the way the stories say? This class will look at the sources, consider how medieval chroniclers shaped their accounts, and ask what the legend tells us about how we misunderstand the Middle Ages.

7) English

Sir Gawain and the Green Knight

Sir Gawain and the Green Knight is one of the great poems of medieval England, part of the body of Arthurian legend. It tells of Gawain's bargain with a mysterious green stranger and the test of honour that follows. This class will read selections from Simon Armitage's modern translation and ask how a fourteenth-century poem handles temptation, courage, and the keeping of one's word.

8) General

Stoicism

Stoicism is one of the oldest schools of Western philosophy still in active use today. Its central claim is that what disturbs us is not the world but our judgements about it. This class will read short extracts from Epictetus and Marcus Aurelius on judgement, the present moment, and adversity, and ask how a way of thinking from the Roman Empire still shapes modern psychology.

9) History

The Fall of Constantinople

On 29 May 1453, the Ottoman Sultan Mehmed II breached the walls of Constantinople, ending over a thousand years of the Byzantine Empire. This class will focus on interpreting sources from both sides of the siege and consider the nature of empire and religious conflict, and what happens when a civilisation that has lasted a millennium comes to an end.

10) English

The Poetry of Simon Armitage

Simon Armitage is the current Poet Laureate, and one of the most widely read poets writing in Britain today. His work is plain-spoken, often funny, and rooted in ordinary contemporary life, yet it handles serious subjects with great control. This class will read a selection of his poems and consider how a modern poet uses everyday language, voice, and form — and how the familiar techniques of poetry look when the subject matter is wholly of our own time.

11) General

Aliens and UFOs

The universe contains billions of galaxies, each with billions of stars, and yet we have never found a single trace of life beyond our own planet. This class will weigh the question the physicist Enrico Fermi is said to have asked — if the universe is so vast, where is everybody? — against the long history of reported sightings of UFOs. We will ask what would actually count as good evidence for life elsewhere, why people are so ready to believe in it, and how to think clearly about claims that are extraordinary but not impossible.

12) History

Kett's Rebellion

In the summer of 1549, Robert Kett led a rising of the common people of Norfolk against the enclosure of land by wealthy landowners. This class will read sources from the rebellion, consider its causes and the demands the rebels made, and ask why it ended as it did — and what it reveals about power and protest in Tudor England.

13) English

Anglo-Saxon Poetry: Britain after Rome

When the Roman legions left Britain in the early fifth century, the island passed into the long, half-lit period we call the Anglo-Saxon age. The poetry that survives from it — anonymous, sombre, and preserved in only a handful of manuscripts — looks out on a world of ruin, exile, and endurance. This class will read Old English poems in both the original and modern translation, among them 'The Ruin', which contemplates the broken stonework of a fallen Roman city, and ask how the earliest English literature faced the loss of an older world, and how the language itself has changed in the centuries since.

14) General

Can a Machine Think? Artificial Intelligence

Computers can now beat us at chess, write essays, and hold a conversation — but do any of them actually understand what they are doing? This class will look at the question of artificial intelligence: Alan Turing's famous test for deciding whether a machine can think, and John Searle's 'Chinese Room' argument that it never truly can. We will ask what the difference is between genuinely understanding something and merely appearing to, and look ahead to the idea of the 'singularity' — the point at which a machine might become cleverer than its makers and begin to improve itself beyond our control.

15) History

The Great Fire of London

In September 1666 a fire that began in a baker's shop destroyed much of the City of London. Our knowledge of it rests heavily on the diary of Samuel Pepys,

an eyewitness whose account is vivid but partial. This class will read from Pepys and other sources and use them to ask how far a single famous document can be trusted, which is central to the source work in scholarship history papers.

16) English

The Call of the Wild

Jack London's *The Call of the Wild* (1903) follows Buck, a domestic dog stolen and sold into the harsh world of the Klondike gold rush, as he reverts to something wilder and older. This class will read from the novel and consider how a writer builds a convincing non-human point of view, and what the story has to say about instinct, civilisation, and survival.

17) General

The Problem of Consciousness

What does it mean to be aware? This class will look at the so-called 'hard problem' of consciousness: the question of why we have subjective experience at all. We will consider ideas from thinkers such as David Chalmers and Daniel Dennett, as well as from older traditions, and ask whether science can ever fully explain what it is like to be a thinking, feeling creature, or whether consciousness is something that will always resist explanation.

18) History

The Trial of Socrates

In 399 BC, Socrates was tried, convicted, and sentenced to death in Athens on charges of corrupting the youth and impiety. This class will look at the political context of democratic Athens, consider the nature of the charges, and ask a difficult question: can a society that values free speech ever be justified in silencing one of its citizens?

19) English

Poetry of the End of the World

Few subjects have drawn poets more consistently than the end of the world. This class will read poems on the theme of apocalypse — among them Frost's 'Fire and Ice', the closing vision of Eliot's 'The Hollow Men', and a passage from the Book of Revelation — and look closely at how form and figurative language give shape to the unimaginable.

20) General

The Trolley Problem

A runaway tram will kill five people unless you divert it onto a track where it will kill one. Should you? This class will use the trolley problem and its

variations to examine how we make moral judgements — when we count consequences, when we refuse to, and why our intuitions so often pull in opposite directions.

21) **History**

The Haitian Revolution

Beginning in 1791 and ending in independence in 1804, the Haitian Revolution was the only successful large-scale slave revolt in history. This class will consider how enslaved people organised resistance against one of the most brutal colonial regimes in the Caribbean, and ask why this revolution is so often overlooked in Western histories.

22) **English**

Invisible Cities

Italo Calvino's *Invisible Cities* (1972) imagines a conversation between the explorer Marco Polo and the emperor Kublai Khan, in which Polo describes a series of impossible cities he claims to have visited. This class will read several of these short descriptions and ask how a writer can fold philosophical ideas — about memory, desire, and signs — into imaginative prose.

23) **General**

The Science and Philosophy of Sleep

We spend roughly a third of our lives asleep, yet for centuries nobody could explain why. This class will draw on neuroscience, psychology, and philosophy to ask what sleep is, what happens when we dream, and why sleep deprivation is so destructive. We will also look at how different cultures have understood dreams — as prophecy, as therapy, as nonsense — and ask whether modern science has improved on older ways of thinking.

24) **History**

Fighting for the Vote

The right to vote in Britain was not given but won, over more than a century of campaigning. This class will read sources from across that long struggle — from the Chartists to the suffragettes — and compare the tactics different movements used, asking why some succeeded where others failed, and what part violence and non-violence played.

25) **English**

Oscar Wilde, 'The Ballad of Reading Gaol'

Imprisoned in Reading Gaol in 1895, Oscar Wilde wrote a long ballad about a fellow prisoner condemned to hang. This class will read extracts from 'The

Ballad of Reading Gaol' and consider how Wilde uses the old ballad form — its refrains and its plain language — to turn a private experience of suffering into a public argument about cruelty and the possibility of redemption.

26) **General**

Knowledge and Doubt

How do you know you are not dreaming, or being deceived at every turn by some powerful illusion? This class will follow Descartes as he tries to doubt everything he can, in search of one thing that cannot be doubted, and ask whether his famous answer — 'I think, therefore I am' — really does rebuild knowledge from the ground up.

27) **History**

The Difference Between the Wars

This class is built around two speeches: one by Rudyard Kipling from the early days of the First World War, the other by Winston Churchill during the Second. Read together, they show how profoundly the British understanding of war changed in the years between, and how much of that change was driven by technology.

28) **English**

Ernest Hemingway, A Moveable Feast

Ernest Hemingway's *A Moveable Feast* is a memoir of his years as a young writer in Paris in the 1920s, written with great pleasure about food, drink, friendship, and work. This class will read extracts and use them to study figurative language and the famously plain Hemingway style, in which a great deal is carried by very simple sentences.

29) **General**

Plato's Allegory of the Cave

Roughly 2,400 years ago, Plato put into the mouth of his teacher Socrates one of philosophy's most enduring images: a cave of prisoners watching shadows on a wall, mistaking them for reality. This class will read the three connected passages from the *Republic* — the Sun, the Divided Line, and the Cave — and follow the philosopher's ascent from the world of appearances to the world of forms.

30) **History**

The Iraq War of 2003

The invasion of Iraq in 2003 is recent enough that it can feel like news rather than history, yet it is now far enough back to be studied as the past. This class

will read contemporary sources on the war and its justification, and consider how events within living memory come to shape the present — and how historians begin to handle a subject still close to hand.

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Classes will be followed by a brief yet precisely-honed homework task tailored specifically to give students an opportunity to put into practice the skill we have been studying.

Yours,
Dr. Sam